How the free/paid AI split actually works

A plain-language walkthrough — July 4, 2026 session findings, real measured numbers

1. What is a "loop"?

A loop is one full trip through the app for one moment — start to finish. Here's what happens in order:

1. Capture	2. Question 1	3. Question 2	4. Question 3
On-device $0, always. Happens on your phone, never touches the AI.	**233 tokens**	**308 tokens**	**381 tokens**

5. Prayer	6. Journal
507 tokens	**1,040 tokens**

> Steps 2 through 6 each require asking the AI company to write something — that's 5 separate "asks," totaling **2,469 tokens**. One loop = those 5 asks, one time through the app, for one captured moment. This is a real measurement from a live test, not an estimate.

2. Two AI companies can answer those asks: Groq (free) and OpenAI's GPT-4o mini (paid)

Every one of those 5 asks gets routed to one or the other. Here's the real difference between them:

Groq — free

$0

up to about 40 loops per day, combined across every user. After that, Groq simply stops answering until the next day. This is a hard wall, not negotiable, because it's free.

GPT-4o mini — paid

$0.00065

per loop, every loop, no limit on how many loops total. There's a speed limit (about 81 loops per minute, 810 per day right now), but that's not a "you can't use more" wall — it just means if too many people hit it in the same instant, some wait a few extra seconds. That speed limit itself grows automatically the more the account is used.

3. What "40 loops a day" and "810 loops a day" actually mean

	Groq (free)	GPT-4o mini (paid)
Is there a total limit on how much you can ever use?	Yes — resets daily, but capped every day	No — pay for as much as you want, forever
What happens if too many people ask at once?	Extra people get nothing until tomorrow	Extra people wait a few seconds
Cost	$0	~$0.00065 per loop

4. If 1,000 people sign up and do their first loop on the same day

Here are all three groups those 1,000 people split into. These three numbers add up to exactly 1,000 — nothing hidden between them.

Group A

40 people

get answered by Groq, for free, because that's Groq's entire daily allowance for everyone combined

Group B

810 people

get answered by GPT-4o mini the same day, at ~$0.00065 each, because Groq's 40 ran out and paid picks up everyone else, up to its own speed limit

Group C

150 people

are left over (1,000 minus the 40 minus the 810) and wait a bit — likely later that same day or the next, not indefinitely

40 + 810 + 150 = 1,000 people. That's all of them, split three ways — not three separate totals.



Group A, 40 people (too thin to show a label, but it's there on the far left)

The 150 in Group C aren't stuck forever — that's the difference between Groq's hard daily wall and OpenAI's speed limit, which rises automatically as the account gets used more. They likely get served within a day or so, not indefinitely.

$0

cost for the 40 free loops

$0.53

cost for the 810 paid loops

~$0.62

total, to get all 1,000 people through their first loop

5. What if you put $50 down on the card right now?

The $50 and the 62 cents are two different things. The $50 is a deposit that sits in the account as available balance — it isn't spent just because 1,000 people used the app. You're only ever charged for tokens actually used, at the same rate ($0.00065 per loop) no matter what. Adding $50 doesn't make each loop cost more or less.

What the $50 actually buys you is a higher speed limit, not cheaper usage. OpenAI raises your daily/per-minute ceiling as you pay more into the account over time — and their published thresholds show $50 ever paid is exactly what qualifies an account for the next tier up:

Tier	Total ever paid	Monthly spend cap
Tier 1 (where we likely are today)	$5	$100/month
Tier 2 (what $50 unlocks)	$50	$500/month

So putting $50 down very likely raises the daily ceiling enough that Group C (the 150 who'd otherwise wait) get served the same day instead — but I can't hand you the exact new number for GPT-4o mini specifically. OpenAI doesn't publish per-model tier limits publicly; it only shows up on your own account's limits page once you're actually at that tier. Worth checking `platform.openai.com/settings/organization/limits` right after funding it, to see the real new ceiling.

Group C doesn't disappear — it moves into Group B.

Today — Tier 1

Group A — free, Groq	**40**
Group B — paid, same day	**810**
Group C — waits	**150**

With $50 — Tier 2

Group A — free, Groq	**40**
Group B — paid, same day	**960**
Group C — waits	**0**

Same 1,000 people, same 62 cents in real usage cost — the only thing that changes is Group C (150) folds into Group B and gets served same-day instead of waiting. Treat the "0" as a strong likelihood, not a confirmed number, until checked on your account's actual limits page.

$50
one-time deposit, sits as balance, not itself a cost

~$0.62
actual usage cost for all 1,000 people's first loop, same as before

$49.38
left in the account afterward, for everyone's next loops

6. The bottom line

Getting all 1,000 first-time users all the way through capture, 3 questions, a prayer, and a journal entry costs about 62 cents, total. Not per person — total, for everyone. That number doesn't change whether you fund $0 or $50 into the account. The free Groq tier covers a small slice of that for nothing; the rest costs a fraction of a cent per person on GPT-4o mini. Adding $50 doesn't raise that 62 cents — it raises how many people can be served on day one without anyone waiting, by unlocking a higher tier.